

The Island market, and where our work comes from

A read on Greater Victoria and Nanaimo for a structural practice: what is actually being built, who competes for the engineering seat, which door our work enters through — and the live signals worth acting on this month. Prepared for Rory Beirne, Principal, Vancouver Island.

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ANALYSIS

The shape of the market

Greater Victoria and Nanaimo are not one market. They are a very large volume of small residential work, a thin band of institutional projects that are almost all timber, and — between them — a mid-market that is bigger by value than either and far less contested.

Q1 2026 housing starts ran **Saanich 195, Langford 171, Colwood 143, City of Victoria 117**. That ordering is itself the story: the two busiest start markets on the Island are suburban, not urban, and the City of Victoria is fourth. March starts fell 64% year over year while missing-middle activity doubled on the back of Bill 44. The Island is building more units in smaller buildings, further out.

The application files show the same thing from the other end. **Saanich files 535 single-lot residential building permits against 91 commercial, industrial or institutional permits** — a six-to-one ratio. Nanaimo's descriptions have shifted to the language of the missing middle: three-storey fourplexes, triplexes with attached suites, two-storey four-unit stratas. This is a market with enormous transaction volume and a small average job.

► WHERE THE VALUE ACTUALLY SITS

Langford is the only Island city that publishes a construction value, and it settles the question. **147 permits between \$500k and \$2M are worth \$155.7M — more than the eight largest permits on the file combined (\$141.5M).** The towers are visible; the money is in the tier below them.

That tier is also where a mid-sized structural practice has the clearest advantage. A \$26M tower attracts RJC and the nationals. A \$1.2M four-storey does not, and there are 147 of them in one city.

Above that band sits a small institutional pipeline that behaves completely differently — long lead times, public funding, and a strong material preference. **Both flagship post-secondary projects on the Island are mass timber:** VIU Nanaimo's 266-bed ten-storey hybrid CLT, and Camosun Lansdowne's 423-bed six-storey mass-timber build at \$154.7M targeting LEED Platinum. Neither is an outlier. The Island's design bench has reorganised around performance and timber to match, and the fastest-growing practices in this document are the Passive House and mass-timber ones.

The third force is the building stock. Victoria has one of the oldest and most seismically exposed inventories in Canada, and the public sector is now pricing that risk explicitly — Island Health frames the **\$75.6M Victoria General Hospital energy centre** as resilience against power outages, earthquakes and flooding. It is a seismic brief in all but name. Nanaimo's file carries the private-sector version: *"remediation and repair to existing 2 storey commercial building to address do not occupy and illegal construction"* at 2253 Wilgress Rd, and an occupancy-change renovation of a two-storey industrial building at 668 Pine St.

Read together, the market rewards three things: volume capability at the small end, timber and performance credentials at the institutional end, and seismic assessment of existing

buildings across both. Our competitors have already worked this out — see section 03.

POSITION

Which door our work comes through — and the gap

Structural work enters through four doors on the Island. Our ledger says we are strong in one of them and almost absent from another, and that is the single most useful thing in this document.

- ♦ **Developer-led.** A repeat developer client brings us onto each project. This is overwhelmingly how KOR works: Northland 369 projects, Reliance 82, Intracorp 46, Townline 36, Primex 9. **Roughly 555 jobs across our developer and owner clients.**
- ♦ **Architect-led.** The architect assembles the consultant team and names the structural engineer. On the Island this is how most institutional and Passive House work is awarded. **We have three architect clients and seven jobs between them** — Mallen Gowing Berzins (6), dHKarchitects (1), and D'Ambrosio, who is set up in Deltek and has never been billed.
- ♦ **Owner-direct.** An institution buys design services itself — the CRD, school boards, faith organisations, health authorities, seniors operators. We have no Island relationship of this kind.
- ♦ **Builder-led.** A volume builder or design-build contractor needs a stamp per job. Low value each, high frequency, and it is how a practice becomes the default in a suburb.

► THE STRATEGIC FINDING

555 jobs through the developer door; seven through the architect door. That ratio is not a description of the Island market — it is a description of us. The Island's institutional and performance work is awarded architect-led, and it is the segment growing fastest. Every Passive House and mass-timber practice in section 04 is a door we are not currently standing in.

It is also the more defensible position. A developer relationship survives as long as the developer keeps building. An architect relationship compounds across every client that architect wins.

The counter-argument is worth stating: the developer door is what has paid for the practice, and Northland alone is a larger relationship than most Island firms have with anyone. Nothing here suggests trading it. The point is that the Island opportunity that is not already ours sits behind a different door, and the firms holding it open are named in section 04.

COMPETITIVE

Who competes for the structural seat

Saanich publishes the applicant of record on a commercial permit, which means the engineering firm on the building is a matter of public record. That is unusually good visibility, and what it shows is that we have two direct competitors resident on this island, not one.

- ♦ **RJC Engineers — the firm to beat.** 770 staff, 311 of them engineers, employee-owned, founded 1948, with a standing Nanaimo office. **They are named as the applicant on four Saanich commercial permits** — 104-81 Gorge Rd W, 2410 Lee Ave, 2971 Qu'Appelle St and 4461 Interurban Rd.

What matters is not the size but the positioning. Their published capability list leads with structural engineering, **seismic**, structural restoration, **heritage restoration** and **mass timber**. That is KOR's list, in KOR's order, from a firm with twenty offices and a permanent Island presence. They are not flying in for the big jobs; they are filing routine commercial permits in Saanich.

Where they are beatable: a 311-engineer firm has a cost structure to match. On the \$500k–\$2M tier that carries most of Langford's value, and with the builder-designer clients in section 05, responsiveness and fee will beat brand.

- ♦ **Sense Engineering — the one to watch.** Founded 2014 by Brennan Vollering and Ted Denniston, **headquartered in Victoria**, 130 staff, ten offices with Victoria listed first, and headcount up 29% in two years. Structural engineering, building envelope, restoration and **seismic assessment**.

A twelve-year-old firm at 130 people, growing at that rate, from a Victoria base, is the most direct competitive threat in this document. They are building exactly the practice the market described in section 01 rewards, and they have the home-field advantage we would otherwise claim.

- ♦ **Herold Engineering** — Nanaimo civil and structural, and the recurring structural partner on Westmark's projects. Westmark is a KOR client; Herold is the incumbent engineer on their work. That is a specific, named position to contest rather than a general competitor.
- ♦ **McCuaig & Associates** — 42 staff, up 39% in two years. Building science, concrete restoration and **heritage restoration**, focused on assessment and renovation of existing buildings. Adjacent rather than head-on, but it overlaps our heritage lane precisely.
- ♦ **EVOKE Buildings Engineering** — envelope and building science, employee-owned, founded 2020. Not a structural competitor, but they get engaged early on exactly the projects we want, which makes them a teaming candidate as readily as a rival.

- ♦ **Fast + Epp** — holds the structural seat on VIU's 266-bed hybrid CLT student housing, the flagship Island mass-timber project. On the marquee timber job, a competitor already has it.

× THE PATTERN TO TAKE SERIOUSLY

Three of the four resident competitors lead their marketing with seismic work on existing buildings. RJC, Sense and McCuaig have all organised around restoration, envelope and seismic assessment rather than new-build design. They have read the same building stock and the same public-sector signals, and they got there first.

Nine engineering firms filed a Saanich commercial permit in the period on file. **None of them was us.** That is not lost bids — it is a picture of who is embedded with the Saanich commercial owner base.

THE MARKET

The design bench

The architects who decide who sits in the structural seat. These are the practices that matter, and the ones defining where the Island's design work is going.

- ♦ **Low Hammond Rowe** — Saanich, 23 staff, founded 1985. Partners Jackson Low, Paul Hammond, Christopher Rowe. **Passive House and hybrid mass timber**, university buildings, libraries, market and non-market multi-family, seniors housing and care, recreation. Headcount **up 58% in two years**.

On paper the closest fit in this market to what KOR does. Island-native, growing fast, and working in exactly the two areas — timber and institutional — where the Island pipeline is concentrated. If section 02's architect-door argument is right, this is the first call.

- ♦ **dHKarchitects (de Hoog & Kierulf)** — Victoria and Nanaimo, 14 staff, founded 2001. **Already a KOR client**, one project July 2025, and growing at **62% over two years**. Multi-family, affordable housing, seniors and complex care, institutional, marina work. Their own positioning is deep Vancouver Island knowledge — regional logistics and complex municipal codes — which is a claim about relationships as much as design.

The warmest architect door we have, and the relationship is one job deep against a firm expanding by two-thirds.

- ♦ **Continuum Architecture** — Victoria, 519 Pandora Ave, 13 staff. **Founded 1910 and the oldest practice in the city**, rebranded from KPL James in 2020. Healthcare, seniors care, advanced education, industrial, mixed-use. LEED Platinum, certified living-wage employer. Filed both a rezoning and a development permit at 1514 Cedar Hill Cross Rd on the same day — a firm taking a project through from land use.
- ♦ **hcma architecture + design** — 210 staff, Vancouver-based with a Victoria studio, Certified B Corp. Recreation, civic, libraries, healthcare, education. **The VIU 266-bed CLT architect**, and they filed a development permit at 1705 Lansdowne Rd on 10 Aug 2026, on Camosun's doorstep.

High value, contested. Fast + Epp holds their timber structural seat. Worth pursuing on the civic and recreation side rather than head-on.

- ♦ **MJM Architect** — Victoria, 531 Yates St. Principal Michael Moody, filing across two cities. The firm leads its stated capabilities with **seismic upgrades**, adaptive re-use and heritage buildings.

The strongest thematic match on this page. A practice whose front-page offer is seismic upgrading needs a structural partner on every job it wins, and section 03 says three competitors are already selling into that space.

- ♦ **D'Ambrosio Architecture + Urbanism** — Victoria, 14 staff, **four live Victoria applications, the most of any architect in the city**. Erica Sangster and Michael Barros both file. **Set up in Deltek and never billed** — the widest gap between measured activity and relationship in this market.

- ♦ **Cascadia Architects** — Victoria, 15 staff, founded 2012 by Peter Johannknecht and Gregory Damant, who is the named filer. **Passive House specialists**, including large affordable-housing projects. Three live applications.
- ♦ **Studio 531 Architects** — Victoria, founded 2012 by Tom Moore and Jesse Garlick. **Mass timber**, institutional, healthcare, heritage. Works with the Capital Regional District and has teamed with Stantec. **Headcount up 75% in twelve months — the fastest-growing architect on the Island.**
- ♦ **NES Architecture** — **the busiest architect across all five files, seven applications**, most recently 2 Sep 2026, doing Saanich commercial work on Shelbourne St, Tillicum Rd and Douglas St. There is almost no public profile on this firm and no KOR relationship.

The largest unknown in this document. A practice filing at that rate in Saanich commercial is either worth knowing well or worth understanding why not.

- ♦ **Also on the file and credible: Fold** (Passive House certified, net-zero, First Nations housing) · **Colin Harper Architect** (two staff, three live applications, adaptive reuse — converted the Powerhouse Building into Ecologyst's HQ) · **Christine Lintott** (regenerative and ecological design) · **Finlayson Bonet** (supportive and transitional housing, Step Code, Passive House) · **Alan Lowe Architect** (a former Mayor of Victoria in practice — civic reach as much as design authority).

► THE GATEKEEPERS WHO ARE NOT ARCHITECTS

Wiser Projects — registered planners, and the route into Indigenous and non-market housing: they work with Indigenous governments, non-profits, CMHC and BC Housing on community-held land. Kaeley Wiseman is filing the three-tower mixed-use rezoning at 829–899 Fort St.

CitySpaces Consulting — forty years of community planning, offices in Vancouver and Victoria, wrote View Royal's Official Community Plan. Affordable housing, Indigenous planning, feasibility.

Strongitharm Consulting — the busiest planning consultant in Saanich, seven applications. **Westplan** — two senior planners, 40 years between them, sitting at the approvals gate.

None of these firms hires a structural engineer. All of them know, months before anyone else, which projects are real.

THE MARKET

Who is buying

Institutional owners buying design directly

- ◆ **Amica Senior Lifestyles** — owned by the **Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan**, 1,700 staff, 34 residences across Ontario, BC and Alberta. Independent living, assisted living and memory care. Filing *Amica on the Gorge* in Saanich.

The strongest cold target in this document. Seniors housing and care is a KOR lane; this is a pension-fund-backed institutional owner that buys design services directly, is building on the Island now, and has no relationship with us.

- ◆ **Capital Regional District** — 950 staff, and a repeat client of Studio 531. Municipal and regional facilities.

- ♦ **Glenlyon Norfolk School · Habitat for Humanity Victoria · BC Muslim Association · Anglican Diocese of BC · Chabad of Vancouver Island** — all filing their own applications. Owner-direct buyers, small individually, and none has a KOR relationship. Section 02's third door.

Developers worth knowing

- ♦ **Aryze Developments** — Victoria, 54 staff, Certified B Corp, headcount up 53% in two years, four live applications. Kieran Lynch and Dan Kwak file. Telus Ocean and The Abbey. A values-led developer in a market that increasingly rewards that.
- ♦ **Islandview Group** — four live Victoria applications, the most active single applicant in the city, and Niall Paltiel now files across two municipalities. No relationship with us at all.
- ♦ **Bayview Place** — the **Roundhouse** master plan in Victoria West: a full spectrum of housing plus a cultural centre, and one of the largest multi-phase plans in the city. Peter de Hoog files.
- ♦ **M'Akola Development Services** — a KOR client, Indigenous-led affordable housing, Island-wide, filing a **22-storey residential with ground-floor commercial at 3075 Douglas St.**
- ♦ **Petroglyph Development Group** — not on any permit file, and still the best cold target in Nanaimo. **te'tuxwtun: 102.7 acres, Snuneymuxw-led, approved 9 May 2026** — the largest single land play in that market.

The builder tier

Patriot Homes files more applications than any other party on the Island — twelve, with White Wolf Homes next at nine. Behind them sits Saanich's builder-designer tier: Seba Construction, GT Mann, Logic Homes, Pentagon Homes, Tyko Design and a dozen more, each filing three to five applications a year. Individually small; collectively they are the 535 single-lot permits from section 01, and every one needs a structural stamp.

Two are worth separating out. **Mike Geric Construction** — Saanich, family-owned since 1968, **1,500-plus homes built in Greater Victoria**, and both builder and developer. **Hutchinson Contracting** — heritage restoration, **structural repairs** and second-storey additions, which is a structural engineer's client by definition. **Knappett Projects** is engineer-led — their project

managers are engineers or EITs, and a pitch to them should sound technical rather than commercial.

PUBLIC SECTOR

The institutional pipeline

Long lead times, public funding, and consultant selection that happens years before anything appears as a tender.

- ♦ **Nanaimo Regional General Hospital** — concept planning for a new patient tower plus cardiac and acute expansion, and a new Nanaimo Cancer Centre. **Concept plan due summer 2027, so consultant selection is ahead of us, not behind.** The largest health opportunity on the Island and the one with time still on the clock.
- ♦ **Victoria General Hospital energy centre** — \$75.6M (Island Health \$52.9M, Capital Regional Hospital District \$22.7M), building summer 2026 to 2029. Framed by the owner as resilience against outages, earthquakes and flooding.
- ♦ **Camosun Lansdowne student housing** — 423 beds, six storeys, mass timber, LEED Platinum, \$154.7M, ready early 2029.
- ♦ **VIU Nanaimo student housing** — 266 beds, ten storeys, hybrid CLT, on VIU's district geo-exchange, opening summer 2027. hcma architect, **Fast + Epp structural**.
- ♦ **BC Housing, Nanaimo** — 564 Fifth Street with M'akola (34 replacement homes plus roughly 165 new, construction 2028) and 250 Terminal Avenue. A 22-unit complex-care building is already on the permit file at 1850 Boxwood Rd.

Every project on this list is either explicitly timber or explicitly seismic. That is not a coincidence and it is the credential set to lead with on the Island.

ACT ON THESE

Hot signals

Specific, dated, and live. A development application is filed **months to years before a tender** — by the time a structural RFP appears, the engineer was chosen at roughly the stage these represent.

Three calls with no introduction required

D'Ambrosio / DAU Studio, SHAPE Properties and **Ledcor Construction** are all set up as clients in Deltek, all filing on the Island, and **none has ever been billed**. No credentials to establish. D'Ambrosio is named on four live Victoria applications.

Two dormant clients who are active again

Aragon Properties has not billed since November 2021 and is filing three Saanich applications as *Aragon (Cordova Bay) Properties*. **Sakura Developments** has not billed since November 2024 and is filing three in Victoria. A dormant client back on the file is a call with a subject line attached.

Firms filing now that we already bill

FIRM	KOR HISTORY	DELTEK
Northland Properties	369 projects · last 26 Aug 2026	CL00299
Reliance Properties	82 projects · last 19 Jan 2026	CL00356
Intracorp Projects	46 projects · last 25 Jun 2026	CL00205
Townline	36 projects · last 5 Feb 2026	7A3C11F3
Mallen Gowing Berzins architect	6 projects · last 7 Aug 2025	CL00257
Greystar Development West	2 projects · last 24 Feb 2026	25F5A4E6
GWL Realty Advisors	2 projects · last 11 Oct 2023	CL00167

FIRM	KOR HISTORY	DELTEK
dHKarchitects architect	1 project · last 31 Jul 2025	D5BE2C6A
M'Akola Development Services	1 project · last 20 Oct 2025	ce787f97

Applications open right now, with the party acting

FILED	SITE	PROPOSED	ACTING
31 Aug 2026	3839 Quadra St	Development permit amendment	Abstract Developments
26 Aug 2026	5166 Cordova Bay Rd	Rezoning	Alan Lowe Architect
20 Aug 2026	1252 Gladstone Ave	Four-storey mixed-use	Tonny Kiptoo
14 Aug 2026	4088 & 4094 Lochside Dr	Development permit	Francl Architecture
10 Aug 2026	1705 Lansdowne Rd	Development permit	hcma
13 Jul 2026	4410 West Saanich Rd	Rezoning	Island View Land Mgmt
9 Jul 2026	1514 Cedar Hill Cross Rd	Rezoning + development permit	Continuum Architecture
29 Jun 2026	251 Esquimalt Rd	22-storey affordable tower	Dylan Baird
15 May 2026	350 Douglas St	Six-storey, heritage retained	David Woo · Starlight Inv.
23 Jan 2026	617 Broughton St	12–13 storey mixed-use	GWL Realty · CL00167
9 Dec 2025	3075 Douglas St	22-storey + commercial	Holly Pridie · M'Akola
8 Oct 2025	202 Harbour Rd	Vehicle sales, service, cafe, office	Niall Paltiel · Islandview

FILED	SITE	PROPOSED	ACTING
6 Aug 2025	829–899 Fort St	Three mixed-use towers	Kaeley Wiseman · Wiser

Langford: \$326M with no name attached

Langford is the only Island city publishing construction values — **293 priced applications totalling \$326,163,279** — and the only one publishing no applicant at all. These addresses are worth chasing through council agendas or a direct call to the city:

- ♦ **\$23.0M — 2360 City Gate Blvd** and **\$20.5M — 2350 City Gate Blvd**, filed one day apart. **\$43.5M on one site, almost certainly one structural engagement.**
- ♦ **\$26.8M — 837 Hockley Ave** and **\$12.2M — 814 Hockley Ave**. Same street, \$39.0M together.
- ♦ **\$10.0M — 3014 Glen Lake Rd**, filed 3 Mar 2026 — **the only \$10M-plus permit filed this year**, and the freshest large job on the file.
- ♦ **\$22.0M — 2868 Rita Rd · \$17.0M — 830 Goldstream Ave · \$10.0M — 2995 Sooke Lake Rd.**

Structural work described as structural work

Nanaimo's file names the scope rather than the applicant, which occasionally hands you the brief directly. **2253 Wilgress Rd** — *"remediation and repair to existing 2 storey commercial building to address do not occupy and illegal construction."* **668 Pine St** — renovation and occupancy change of a two-storey industrial building under an order. **1850 Boxwood Rd** — 22 units of complex care housing. **521 Third St** — a 31-unit strata apartment with one commercial unit.

× ONE NAME TO GET RIGHT

David Woo is filing 350 Douglas St for Starlight *Investments*, the Toronto REIT behind Harris Green — **not** our client Starlight *Development*, the luxury-retreat fund. Same first word, unrelated firms.

CAVEATS

Before you quote a number

- ♦ **The application data is the cities' own and it is exact** — sites, scope text, applicant names and Langford's valuations are published by the municipalities. Current to 4 September 2026, except Nanaimo, which publishes no dates at all.
- ♦ **Not every city publishes every field.** Saanich names the applicant on 901 of 960 applications and Victoria on 94 of 121. **Langford names none of its 349**, Colwood publishes only "authorized agent/owner", and Nanaimo gives neither name nor date. A firm's absence here means the city did not publish it — not that the firm is inactive.
- ♦ **Coverage is Victoria, Saanich, Langford, Colwood and Nanaimo.** Esquimalt, Oak Bay, Sidney, the Saanich Peninsula, View Royal, Sooke, the Cowichan Valley and everything north of Nanaimo are not yet covered.
- ♦ **Langford's valuation is the owner's declared construction cost** for permit-fee purposes — use it to rank jobs, not to price one.
- ♦ **"Open" means an application, not a funded project.** Applications are withdrawn, stalled and refused. A Deltek history is a far stronger signal than any single row in section 07.
- ♦ **Where a competitor is named as applicant, they filed it** — strong evidence they are the professional of record, not proof of a signed contract.
- ♦ **Firm size, growth rates and founding dates are third-party data**, not individually confirmed; treat them as scale indicators. KOR job counts and Deltek links are ours and are reliable. Fifteen firms have no third-party profile at all and are named from the city's own applicant string — including NES Architecture.

- ♦ **Verify before approaching Casman Group** — our match resolves to a Fort McMurray head office against a 250 phone number.